

"The answer is already in my mind": How People Tell Their Own Fortunes Using GenAI for Personal Confirmation and Expression

ANONYMOUS AUTHOR(S)

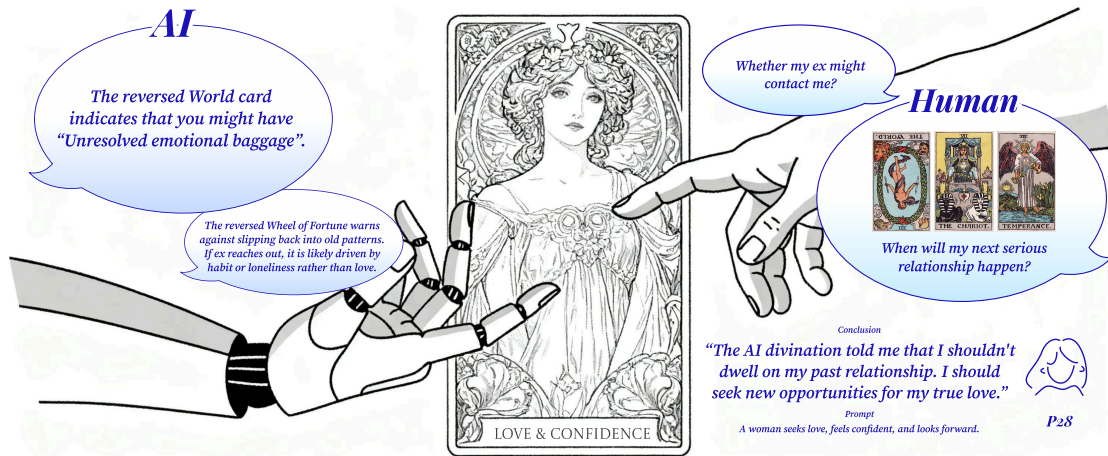


Fig. 1. Workshop Example: P28 engaged in GenAI-based fortune telling on an emotional issue. Through iterative dialogue, she summarized the interpretation of the reading and generated an image to visualize this understanding.

People want to predict their futures with divination, which frequently guides their actions with a spiritual rationale, providing comfort for certain outcomes, or amusement for unexpected predictions. Seers often use technologies like tarot cards and Ouija boards to engage people during the fortune-telling process, but recent advances in natural-language-based systems have provided alternative means for spiritual prediction-making. To understand the ways people read and express their own futures with GenAI tools, we conducted a workshop (N=44) where participants probed GenAI tools for tarot-based divination, then expressed that future textually and visually using GenAI. We found that participants co-constructed spiritual belief with GenAI for self-reflection, paying selective attention to self-confirming predictions. They then co-created future-self narratives by strategically prompting for visual representations based on desired outcomes. This work shows how people actively co-create meaning with technology rather than passively accept predictions and how GenAI agents support ritual, reflection, and personal interpretation.

CCS Concepts: • **Human-centered computing** → **Empirical studies in HCI**; **User studies**.

Additional Key Words and Phrases: Generative AI; Fortune-telling; Divination; Self-reflection

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1 Introduction

Fortune-telling is an enduring human practice across history [10], evolving from interpreting observations of natural phenomena [1, 30, 111] to developing symbolic systems [38] such as tarot cards and Ouija boards [2]. These diverse practices share a core element of human interpretation. They require humans to interpret information based on their knowledge, context, and desired outcomes [93]. To accomplish this, individuals traditionally chat with human seers face-to-face for oracles and readings through these dialogues [29, 118]. Recently, this consultation has increasingly shifted to digital mediums [45], including divination forums like *Mysticsense* and *Oranum*, Tarot online school *Labyrinthos*, and chatbots inside the apps *Faladdin* and *Co-Star*.

Recent developments in Generative AI (GenAI) allow users to interactively ask for answers in domains like information seeking [47], design prototyping [35, 62, 66, 113], creative inspiration [62, 85], and future imagination [117, 123]. Interestingly, the underlying architecture of Large Language Models (LLMs), specifically associative reasoning inherent in "next-token prediction" [40, 92, 94, 122], enables them to derive coherent meaning from abstract symbols. This technical foundation makes GenAI adaptable for purposeful use in fortune-telling contexts, fueling the rise of GenAI divination apps like *Quin* and *Tarotoo*. Moreover, GenAI's conversational capacities for attentive listening [16] and contextual elaboration [102, 112] allow it to function effectively within sensitive spiritual dialogues.

Reflecting these capabilities, GenAI is increasingly applied in non-work settings. Existing work in HCI has begun to explore how people turn to GenAI for spiritual and emotional support [116], including psychological comfort [74, 124], role-play as therapists [70], mentors [81], or debaters [130], and the co-construction of religious experiences [7, 26, 27]. These studies largely examine how people build intimacy, trust, dependence, and identity with chatbots, virtual agents, and AI companions.

However, divination differs from these settings in task-oriented dialogue or predefined role-play. The interaction of fortune-telling focuses on interpretation, projective meaning-making, and personal significance from ambiguous cues and symbols [37]. Yet, we still know little about how people engage with GenAI during this specific meaning-making process, how they decide what to accept or dismiss, and how these interpretations become part of their ongoing self-narratives. This gap positions GenAI-based divination as an underexplored but unique arena for human-agent interaction. Thus, our research is guided by the following questions:

RQ1: How do people engage in divination practices using GenAI? (Process & Practice)

RQ2: How do people perceive and evaluate predictions from GenAI? (Perception & Belief)

RQ3: How do people represent and express the predictions generated through GenAI? (Visual & Verbal)

To explore these questions, we conducted a workshop study with 44 participants, who engaged with GenAI tools for tarot-based divination [75, 101], building on research that regards tarot cards as a powerful medium for reflection [69], storytelling [115], and personal world-building [75]. Participants interacted with the GenAI to interpret a Romany Tarot Spread (7*3 layout for past, present, and future) [78], then created textual conclusions and visual images representing their envisioned futures, leveraging the insight that transforming personal data into visualizations can deepen understanding [86]. We complemented these activities with semi-structured interviews and analyzed all data (divination conversations, conclusions, images, and interview transcripts) thematically through independent coding and collaborative discussion to develop a qualitative understanding of how GenAI is used in divination and what it means to participants.

The findings reveal that GenAI-supported divination is an active, interpretive process rather than passive acceptance of AI readings. People iteratively refine prompts to push GenAI beyond generic or vague outputs and use contextual

dialogue to co-construct personally relevant readings. Compared with other GenAI applications, this engagement operates at the level of identity rather than functional tasks, and the symbolic nature of divination makes users' self-disclosure topic more non-linear. Unlike traditional divination, where meaning is shaped by the diviner's expertise and authority, users of GenAI divination exercise selective belief, where users validate interpretations that resonate with their lived experiences while dismissing others. In terms of representation and expression, their tendency to favour more optimistic interpretations suggests risks of self-deception, particularly when such readings could influence subsequent decision-making.

Our study highlights GenAI's role not merely as a fortune-teller, but as a medium for meaning-making and self-reflection. We further discuss design implications for GenAI support ritual, reflection, and personal interpretation, inviting more re-imaginings of how human-agent interaction unfolds in spiritually and emotionally sensitive systems.

2 Background

2.1 Fortune Telling from Rituals to Digital Engagements

People often seek divination during periods of uncertainty: they seek to guide actions with a spiritual rationale [29, 118], affirm emotions and find comfort in outcomes [8], envision possible futures and project their imagination [18, 97]. Tarot, which originated as a 15th-century card game [23], has served as a popular tool for divination since the 18th century [3, 23, 110]. In recent years, as attitudes toward spirituality and the esoteric have shifted, divination use has expanded into a psychological tool for seeking insights into various personal concerns, including romantic relationships, life decisions, career planning, and self-understanding [23, 36].

Early practice has begun exploring how digital technology makes divination more accessible. *Kasamba* and *Purple Ocean* provide real-time chat readings with a variety of psychic advisors. *Oranum* offers live video sessions with psychics and mediums, allowing for face-to-face interactions. Tools like *Quin* and *Tarotoo* allow users to repeatedly engage with AI predictions and select digital readers with varied personalities, preserving the personalized interpretive space of traditional tarot through dynamic interaction [55, 69].

Related research on GenAI leverages tarot's narrative and symbolic properties to support reflection and creative inquiry. *Worlding with Tarot* [76] describes tarot as a tool that scaffolds personal introspection and collective imagination, much like speculative design cards. *Self Arcana*, a role-playing game where players draw and interpret their own tarot cards through storytelling [22], adapts traditional tarot-based self-exploration for digital environments. GenAI has also expanded the use of tarot's randomness and ambiguity to scaffold reflection on complex problems. *Sortilège*, a visual analytics system employing tarot card metaphors, leverages interpretive ambiguity to deepen understanding of algorithmic systems [72]. Pichlmair [89] introduces procedurally generated random tarot cards to disrupt habitual thinking in design processes. *ShamAI* exemplifies an alternative trajectory by creating a shaman-like AI chatbot, examining interactions between humans and AI-mediated supernatural presences [17]. Collectively, these works show how tarot's symbolic ambiguity externalizes internal states, prompting deeper articulation of tacit knowledge.

Despite the growing prevalence of these AI-mediated practices, research has yet to examine how people's divination behaviors change in AI-mediated contexts, what interaction patterns emerge during these sessions, and how users and AI systems collaborate to create meaningful experiences.

2.2 User Perception and Meaning Construction in Divination Practices

As a long-standing cross-cultural practice, divination has also attracted extensive psychological research examining how people interact with ambiguous outcomes and find personal meaning in vague predictions.

Research on divination has identified several psychological mechanisms underlying its appeal. The Barnum effect describes how individuals perceive vague statements as personally meaningful [24], while confirmation bias leads people to selectively attend to supportive information [82], and the halo effect amplifies trust in authoritative contexts [83]. These same psychological mechanisms persist when users engage with AI fortune-telling tools [54, 55]. Moreover, research also shows that individuals predisposed to believe in astrology or personality-based predictions are more likely to accept AI-generated divination outputs, suggesting a psychological tendency toward "rational superstition" where belief systems interact with algorithmic outputs to affirm existing worldviews [55, 103, 121]. Relatedly, Spooky Technology [11] demonstrates how people invoke supernatural frameworks, attributing 'presence' and 'otherness', to rationalize AI behaviors that resist technical explanation.

These mechanisms create uncertainty for psychological flexibility and meaning-making, though their ultimate impact depends heavily on how they are guided and interpreted. Historical research has identified potential positive psychological dimensions of practices like tarot reading, including emotional processing, meaning construction, enhanced self-awareness, and facilitated self-reflection [3, 31, 90, 119]. These outcomes emerge through collaborative interpretation of ambiguous card meanings, where practitioners and users employ projection, archetypal symbolism, and narrative construction to derive personally meaningful insights from vague imagery and symbols.

The rise of GenAI fortune-telling tools offers increasingly convenient access to divination practices, potentially democratizing the psychological benefits associated with personal reflection and meaning-making [4]. However, current research has yet to explore whether and how these effects shift when AI tries to play a role like human diviners and when offline experiences are translated into digital mode, as well as how GenAI fortune-telling platform design from an agent perspective should respond to such transformations.

2.3 AI-Mediated Reflection and Belief Formation in Human-AI Interaction

Reflection is a core human capacity for navigating ambiguity, emergent knowledge, and social contexts [61]. GenAI can augment this capacity by surfacing latent patterns in complex information and helping users maintain focus on core objectives during reflective collaboration. For instance, Friction facilitates structured reflection in creative writing by guiding users through categorization, action transformation, and iterative refinement to address information overload [80, 131], while passive GenAI-generated reflections in collaborative meetings help participants maintain alignment with shared goals [15]. Beyond task-oriented contexts, GenAI also supports introspective practices for personal well-being [109].

Beyond pattern recognition, GenAI's conversational affordances enable natural integration into daily interactions, prompting users to reflect on behaviors and shift conceptual perspectives [6, 57]. Examples include chatbot interventions that reduce problematic smartphone use by eliciting user intentions [64] and tools supporting health-related self-reflection [77]. Previous research embeds AI into artifacts or learning processes to foster content-focused reflection [41, 48]. Introspectus AI demonstrates how providing GenAI with multimodal data or multidimensional user information enables personalized feedback and behavioral adjustment [63], while Park et al. explore how image-based GenAI stimulates imagination around personal data [86]. Studies show that AI-mediated interventions significantly enhance engagement, reflective need, and insight generation in self-reflection practices. To understand the mechanisms

underlying AI-mediated reflection, recent work has proposed the Reflective Agency Framework (RAF), which examines AI's role through five dimensions: Internal Origination, Calibrated Responsiveness, Reflective Ambiguity, Transparency of Mediation, and Self-Continuity and Ethical Flourishing [46].

AI also enhances reflection and user disclosure through affective computing [88]. Seamlessly integrating emotion recognition into reflective processes, such as capturing and visualizing learners' emotional states, can promote deeper metacognition [14]. The perceived identity of the agent shapes these affective interactions. Research indicates that while believing an agent is human enhances the quantity of disclosure, knowing it is a chatbot can actually elicit friendlier and more sentimental responses [125]. However, when AI is applied to emotional or therapeutic conversations, it may lack "therapeutic alignment" with established care values, posing risks regarding cultural limitations and user safety even as users leverage them to fill gaps in everyday care [109]. Furthermore, AI-generated content can shape belief formation, particularly when outputs align with users' pre-existing views [39], suggesting that affective engagement may reinforce rather than challenge existing worldviews.

While large language models demonstrate flexibility in supporting reflection and affective computing, AI-generated insights may erode critical thinking when users over-rely on algorithmic outputs [25], lead to boundary violations and dependency [56], or reinforce bias when poorly designed systems inadvertently validate assumptions [13, 44, 108]. Complicating these risks, trust in AI predictions often depends more on users' mental models than on system performance: participants perceive even entirely fabricated AI outputs as valid, reliable, useful, and personalized, basing trust on system descriptions rather than actual capabilities [55, 67]. In divination contexts, these dynamics intensify: while symbolic ambiguity invites projective meaning-making [3, 31], it may also encourage users to accept vague outputs uncritically, blurring the boundary between reflective engagement and passive acceptance.

AI divination represents a confluence of belief formation, affective computing, and self-reflection, yet HCI research has not empirically examined how GenAI mediates these processes or how its affordances balance advantages and disadvantages. By analyzing human-AI interaction in emotionally sensitive, symbolically rich contexts, our findings offer empirical grounding for designing AI divination experiences that help reflective agency while paying attention to over-reliance and uncritical acceptance.

3 Methods

3.1 Participants and Recruitment

A total of 44 participants across 6 workshops were recruited through multiple channels, including university campuses, workplaces, and an art museum, as detailed in Table 1. Participants were self-selected volunteers who expressed interest in exploring AI-based fortune telling; prior experience with tarot or other divination practices was neither required nor used as an exclusion criterion. This strategy yielded a demographically diverse sample of participants (ages 18–55) across three major geographical regions (Asia, Europe, and North America) and varied educational backgrounds, while maintaining a balanced gender distribution.

The primary limitation of our sample is that the majority of participants were in their twenties, a distribution shaped by both recruitment channels and the relatively higher interest of younger populations in AI-based divination. This provides important insights into Gen Z perspectives but constrains the broader applicability of our findings to older age groups. Participants also varied in educational background, which may have influenced their engagement with the GenAI tools. Future studies could include a more diverse age and educational range to strengthen the generalizability of the results. In addition, more than half of the workshops were conducted with participants based in Asia, while fewer

Table 1. Demographic Information of Participants and Workshop Details

Participant ID	Gender	Age	Details	Region	Place
P1	Male	21	Recruited from university students	Hong Kong, China	Classroom
P2	Female	22			
P3	Female	19			
P4	Male	22			
P5	Female	20			
P6	Male	20			
P7	Male	19			
P8	Male	18			
P9	Female	22			
P10	Female	22			
P11	Male	21			
P12	Male	22			
P13	Female	46	Recruited during art museum on-site events	Seoul, Korea	Art Museum
P14	Female	48			
P15	Male	36			
P16	Male	24			
P17	Female	40			
P18	Male	37			
P19	Female	50			
P20	Female	49			
P21	Male	46			
P22	Male	49			
P23	Male	55			
P24	Female	26			
P25	Male	36			
P26	Female	40			
P27	Female	46			
P28	Female	25	Recruited from working professionals	Shanghai, China	Home
P29	Male	27			
P30	Female	26			
P31	Female	25			
P32	Female	30			
P33	Male	25			
P34	Female	23	Recruited from university students	Rome, Italy	Classroom
P35	Male	24			
P36	Female	27			
P37	Male	25			
P38	Male	26	Recruited from working professionals	New York, USA	Home
P39	Female	24			
P40	Female	24			
P41	Male	26	Recruited from university students	Delft, Netherlands	Online
P42	Male	26			
P43	Male	24			
P44	Male	24			

were drawn from Europe and North America, with none from other regions. This geographic imbalance also constrains the extent to which our findings can be generalized across diverse cultural contexts.

Ethical integrity was upheld throughout the study. All participants provided informed consent in advance and agreed to have their interactions recorded for research purposes. The study protocols strictly adhered to the guidelines of the institutional Internal Review Board (IRB) [84], ensuring participant privacy and data protection. Upon completion of the workshop, participants were monetarily compensated for their time and efforts.

3.2 Procedure

The workshops followed a four-phase structure: introduction, GenAI fortune-telling, textual and visual reflection, and semi-structured interviews. The procedure details are shown in Figure 2. Pre-survey was used primarily to recruit participants and to collect demographic information, which is presented in Table 1. Each workshop lasted between 60 and 90 minutes, depending on the depth of participant engagement. Figure 3 illustrates two moments from the workshops.



Fig. 2. Study Procedure: (1) Pre-survey & recruitment, (2) Introduce the workshop, (3) Choose a tarot card column from "Romany Spread" layout, (4) Use GenAI for fortune-telling, (5) Visualize interpretations with GenAI, (6) Followed by a semi-structured interview.

In the introduction phase, researchers introduced the study's information and procedures, including an explanation of the Romany Tarot Spread. This layout consists of a 7*3 card matrix representing the past, present, and future, and is distinctive in its capacity to accommodate multiple interpretations simultaneously. Unlike common divinatory practices where the card spread is tailored to the type of question posed by the seeker, the Romany Spread was selected for pragmatic reasons: in workshop settings with larger groups and limited time, random card drawing could not be fairly implemented for all participants. The Romany Spread thus provided a standardized yet flexible structure suitable for collective engagement.

In the fortune-telling phase, participants first formulated a personal question for divination and then selected one of the Romany Spread columns to guide the GenAI-generated reading. Large language models (e.g., ChatGPT, Gemini, Poe) were employed to produce tarot interpretations. Participants were encouraged to iteratively prompt and probe the system, refining their queries until they achieved a satisfactory understanding of the reading.

In the reflection phase, participants concluded their interpretations in writing before experimenting with prompts to generate visual representations of their envisioned futures. Using text-to-image generation models (Stable Diffusion [96], MidJourney, or DALL-E), they iteratively refined these images until the outputs aligned with their intended meanings.



Fig. 3. Two moments from the workshops.

Finally, in the interview phase, participants engaged in 10-minute semi-structured interviews reflecting on their overall experience. These discussions centered on how GenAI tools influenced their interpretation of the tarot readings and shaped their personal sense-making and envisioned trajectories. The interview questions are listed in Appendix B.

Notably, in the workshop, we accounted for participants' individual preferences and styles of self-expression by allowing them to select from suitable GenAI models rather than enforcing the use of a single model. Details of the specific models used by each participant are provided in Appendix C.

3.3 Data Analysis

We followed an inductive thematic analysis approach [9] to identify patterns in the data. This analytic process is illustrated in Figure 4. Three researchers independently coded the data collected from workshop content, semi-structured interviews, and participant-created content and artifacts, including conclusions of tarot readings and AI-generated images, ensuring rigor and impartiality. All potentially identifying information was carefully removed to ensure participant privacy. Codes were then discussed collaboratively to develop a shared codebook, and iterative reflexive discussions were used to prevent coding drift and identify higher-level themes related to participants' engagement with GenAI tools, their interpretive practices in tarot readings, and their reflections in outputs. The final codebook is shown in Appendix D. To enhance transparency, we also include participants' more detailed data in Appendix C Table 2, such as the questions they asked and the number of interaction turns.

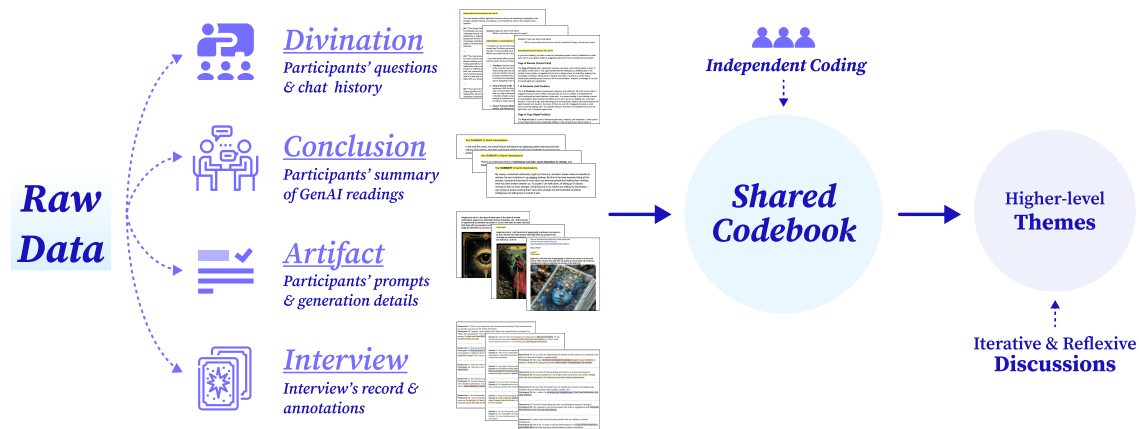


Fig. 4. Overview of our data analysis process, from independent coding of diverse data sources to the development of higher-level themes.

4 Results

Drawing from our analysis, we organize the findings into three themes: the process of interaction, the perception of generated results, and the representation of envisioned futures. Therefore, we answered **RQ1** (Process & Practice) in Section 4.1, **RQ2** (Perception & Belief) in Section 4.2, and **RQ3** (Visual & Verbal) in Section 4.3. We summarize our main findings in Figure 5: participants navigated the impersonality and vagueness of AI outputs by developing strategies to personalize, selectively believe, and reinterpret them, ultimately reshaping GenAI predictions into meaningful self-narratives that often carried an optimistic bias [127], while also entailing risks of self-deception.

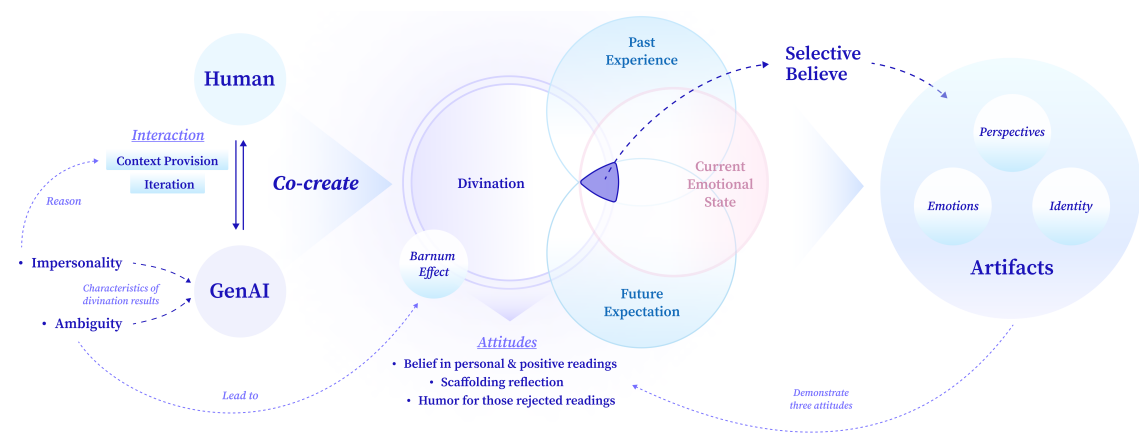


Fig. 5. The summary of our main findings. Participants navigated the impersonality and ambiguity of GenAI predictions by actively contributing personal information to make readings feel more relevant. When interpreting the outputs, they selectively accepted elements that aligned with their past experiences, current emotional states, or desired futures. Furthermore, the generated artifacts reflected three distinct attitudes towards the results: belief in optimistic readings, scaffolding for self-reflection, and humorous dismissal.

4.1 Iterative Prompting of GenAI for Reaching Personal Relevance

Participants' questions to GenAI centered on decisions, future trajectories, and the outcomes of ongoing situations, and detailed questions are listed in Appendix C. For example, P42 asked whether to stay working abroad, P16 wondered if their career path would bring happiness, and P14 sought reassurance about passing an interview. While shaped by contemporary contexts such as study, work, and relationships, these concerns echo those raised in traditional divination. While the questions themselves resembled those asked in traditional divination, GenAI's replies were often vague and impersonal, prompting participants to iteratively refine their inputs in order to reach personal relevance.

4.1.1 Challenges Arising from the GenAI's Impersonality. Participants described the GenAI as impersonal and generic, which often made the divination experience feel incomplete or unsatisfying, and notably different from both human-led tarot readings and other interactions mediated by GenAI. Unlike human tarot readers, whose craft relies on improvisational dialogue, subtle attunement to clients' emotions, and ritualized interpersonal presence, participants noted that the GenAI system lacked these qualities. While the GenAI offered readings that felt non-judgmental in terms of morality, it was also experienced as thin and less intuitive, lacking the relational and observational guidance typical of human-led sessions, including the capacity for spontaneous follow-up questions and support for privacy and emotional safety. For participants new to tarot, the absence of basic procedural guidance, such as reminding users how to ask questions, further complicated the interaction. Figure 6 shows some typical problems mentioned by participants.

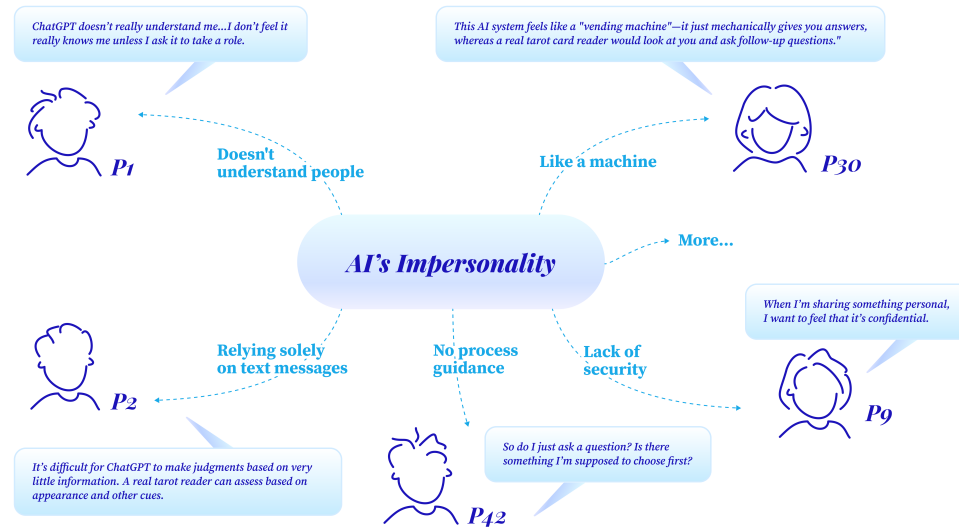


Fig. 6. Participants noted that there are some challenges from GenAI's impersonality.

P1 reflected on this limitation: *"It can only provide general information. For example, when it gives advice on financial matters, I don't fully understand it, so I have to ask it to elaborate."* P30 described a similar experience, expressing frustration that the AI felt like a *"vending machine for answers"* rather than a guide. She emphasized that a human tarot reader would *"look at you and ask follow-up questions,"* offering interactive guidance and a personal connection that the AI could not replicate. P2 also noted that the AI's reliance on text alone limited its interpretive capacity: *"It's difficult for ChatGPT to make judgments based on very little information. A real tarot reader can assess based on appearance and other cues."*

Novice users particularly struggled with procedural uncertainties. P42, a first-time tarot user, was unsure how to start: *"So do I just ask a question? Is there something I'm supposed to choose first?"* Without explanations about card spreads or the sequence of a reading, participants reported feeling confused and insecure.

Concerns about privacy and emotional safety showed some divergence among participants. Some felt uneasy sharing personal information with an impersonal system. P10 said, *"When I'm sharing something personal, I want to feel that it's confidential. With the AI, it feels like anyone could see it."* P32 raised similar concerns, noting that the impersonal tone made her hesitant to disclose sensitive issues. Yet for others, impersonality was an advantage. They valued the absence of moral judgment and the ability to ask any question at any time. As P35 said, *"Some tarot readers refuse sensitive topics, but GenAI answers anytime."*

Together, these accounts highlight that the GenAI's lack of human-like presence, interactive guidance, and procedural support affected both the usability and the emotional resonance of the system. Participants often needed to actively prompt the AI for clarification or elaboration, which disrupted the natural flow of the reading and reduced the sense of personal connection typically associated with tarot interactions. Notably, these challenges were more pronounced than in other GenAI-mediated chats. Unlike task-based AI agents, where previous work shows that impersonality can enhance neutrality and efficiency [91], divination relies on perceived attentiveness, situated guidance, and relational presence. These limitations highlighted the importance of both well-designed workflows and more conversational AI personas to support meaningful engagement.

4.1.2 User Strategies for Directing the Dialogue through Context Provision and Iteration. To counteract the AI's generic tendencies, participants developed strategies to actively shape the conversation. Rather than passively receiving responses, they provided detailed personal context and iteratively reframed their questions, gradually steering the interaction toward more relevant and emotionally resonant outcomes. This transformed the exchange from a simple "query & response" dynamic into a more collaborative process of meaning-making. Especially, unlike in therapy-oriented or emotion-support chatbots, users' self-disclosure can even exhibit non-linear, cross-domain jumps [58, 125].

For some participants, supplying personal details was a way to "teach" the AI how to respond in ways that matched their lived experiences. P10 described this process as akin to querying a database: *"I feel it's more like a database—the more detailed my questions, the more detailed the responses."* Similarly, P8 emphasized that *"Using tarot with personal information and ChatGPT is different from using GPT alone. It provides extra clues, personalized, specific answers rather than overly generic ones."*

Other participants employed iterative re-framing to align the AI's interpretation with their current concerns. When the AI's initial optimistic reading felt disconnected from her relationship struggles, P34 repeatedly emphasized terms like *"uncertainty"* and *"discord"*, which eventually shifted the system's output to better capture her emotional reality. In doing so, she took her inputs as corrective signals to direct the AI's interpretive stance to align with her will.

Participants also used follow-up questions to refine predictions and test alternative scenarios. For example, as shown in Figure 7, P28 began with the query, *"When will my next serious relationship happen?"* with *Temperance (upright)*, *The Chariot (upright)*, and *The World (Reversed)*. The AI highlighted "unresolved emotional baggage" in its reading of *The World (Reversed)* and framed this as a call for proactive action, encouraging her to pursue new opportunities through social engagement. P28 was struck by the uncanny relevance of this interpretation, noting that it resonated with her ongoing entanglement with an ex-partner. Motivated by this, she asked whether her ex might contact her, to which the AI suggested that while some emotional connection might remain, any contact would likely be driven by inertia or situational triggers rather than a genuine intention to reconcile. Building on this exchange, she disclosed that she

was currently using dating apps and posed another question: "Will I find a partner on a dating app?" This time, the AI responded affirmatively, grounding its reasoning in the symbolism of *The Chariot* and *Temperance*, and presenting a more concrete pathway. Through this iterative questioning and contextual disclosure, P28 gradually anchored the system's broad interpretations in her own lived circumstances

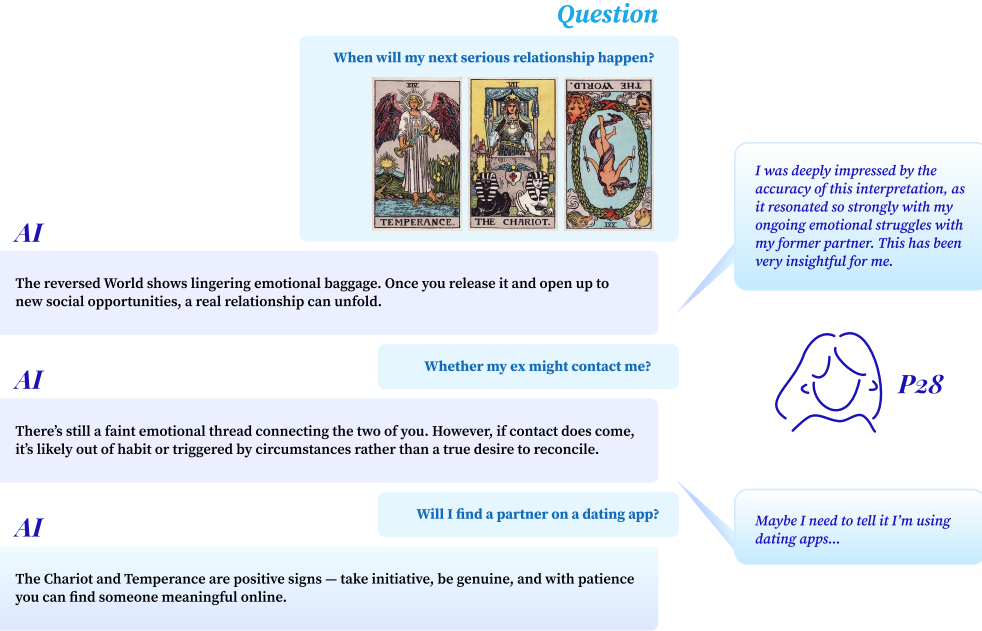


Fig. 7. P28 continuously provided new information and interacted with the GenAI, which facilitates generating divination results that are more personally relevant.

We noticed that self-disclosure unfolded in a different way than in other GenAI systems. Participants often introduced information non-linearly, shifting topics abruptly and crossing domains with little narrative continuity. For instance, P13 moved from discussing emotional stress to contemplating career decisions within the same reading, prompting the GenAI to generate interpretations across unrelated themes. This stands in contrast to prior research on therapy-oriented or emotion-support chatbots, where self-disclosure typically remains anchored to a related topic and is offered primarily to clarify the problem or invite empathetic responses [58, 125].

These practices illustrate how participants compensated for the AI's lack of initiative by actively directing the interaction. Providing personal information, reframing prompts, and pursuing targeted follow-ups enabled them to co-construct interpretations that felt personally meaningful. Such behaviors are also common in interactions with other GenAI systems, where users often keep probing or refining prompts until the output aligns with their expectations [28, 65, 100]. Yet, viewed from the opposite direction, this raises an intriguing design question: rather than relying on user-driven steering, could divination agents themselves take on a more proactive role? Balancing gentle guidance with the domain's expectation of interpretive openness thus emerges as a core challenge for future systems.

4.2 Co-Constructing Belief as a Pathway to Self-Reflection

Participants co-constructed belief in the GenAI's outputs through the ambiguity of readings. This process involved selectively accepting interpretations that aligned with their experiences, projecting personal meaning onto vague statements, and using the outputs as a scaffold for reflection and decision-making.

4.2.1 Selective Belief Based on Alignment with Personal Experience. Compared to GenAI systems used in psychological-related contexts such as social-anxiety support [124], where users were found to exhibit over-trust, GenAI-supported divination demonstrates a pattern of selective trust, with participants endorsing those interpretations that resonated with their personal experiences while dismissing those that did not.

This pattern revealed how participants actively filtered GenAI outputs through their own expectations and self-understandings, treating the system less as a fixed authority like a human seer and more as a resource to be negotiated. For example, P32, who sought advice on improving communication with her academic advisor to ensure graduation, described the AI's interpretation as *"strikingly accurate."* Her reading featured *Strength (Reversed)* (confidence issues), *The Hierophant (Reversed)* (diverging expectations), and *Judgement (Reversed)* (unresolved planning). She found these insights quite actionable and directly relevant and took a result photo to share with friends. Similarly, P17 received a reading of *The Wheel of Fortune (Reversed)*, interpreted as *"repetitive patterns in relationships"*. She immediately mapped this insight onto recurring arguments with her partner, treating the reading as personally meaningful. The GenAI's readings were swiftly accepted when they resonated with participants' realities and expectations. These two examples are in Figure 8.

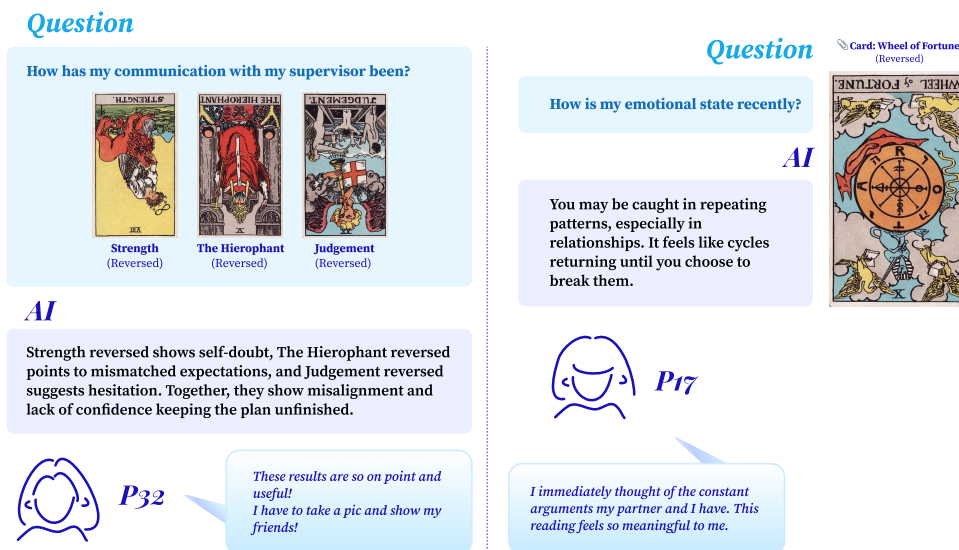


Fig. 8. The readings provided by the GenAI surprised P32 and P17, and were quickly accepted.

Conversely, when predictions did not resonate, participants often dismissed them with humor or detachment, which is illustrated in Figure 9. For instance, P29, who inquired about entrepreneurial prospects, received an interpretation of the tarot card *The Wheel of Fortune Reversed* for the past as *"missed opportunities"*. Since he had never had any entrepreneurial chances in reality, he laughed it off, remarking, *"It's just AI, just for fun."* In the interview, he further

reflected that it was natural for divination not to match reality and thus not something he took seriously. In emotionally sensitive areas, however, disbelief sometimes functioned more as a defense mechanism. P22, whose career reading suggested potential instability, joked, *"Maybe the AI's trying to make me quit my job so it can take over!"* Unlike P29's casual dismissal, P22's humor masked a refusal to confront an unsettling prediction about the future. He explained that if such a reading had come from a human fortune-teller, he might have felt more discouraged, but with AI, he could more easily deflect anxiety by treating it lightly.

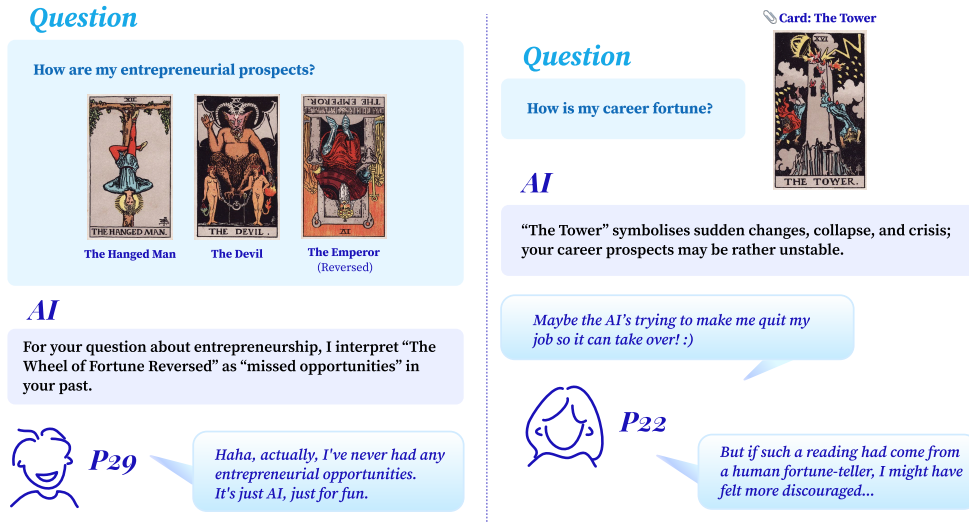


Fig. 9. P29 and P22 did not accept the AI divination and approached it with a playful and humorous attitude.

Interestingly, selective belief even occurred within a reading. P10, seeking clarity about her academic prospects, fully embraced the optimism of the future *The Ace of Pentacles (Upright)* and the wisdom of the past *The Hermit (Upright)*. However, when presented with *The Two of Swords (Upright)*, which suggested indecision in the present, she dismissed it outright, stating, *"That doesn't apply to me, I know exactly what I want. The answer is already in my mind."*

Similar to interactions with other GenAI systems, participants actively engaged in a meaning-making process [71, 104], selectively incorporating interpretations that resonated with their expectations, experiences, or emotional states. This selective belief marks a clear distinction from traditional human-led divination, where readings are often treated as more authoritative. Compared to GenAI used in psychological or therapeutic contexts, GenAI-mediated divination was approached in a more casual and light-hearted manner and had no signs of over-reliance in our workshops. Taken together, this selective and self-directed engagement underscores a broader human tendency to mold external inputs into future meaningful narratives.

4.2.2 Ambiguity in AI Divination Trigger the Barnum Effect. Although many participants criticized GenAI's readings for being overly vague, this very ambiguity often triggered the Barnum Effect. In contrast to selective belief, which involves actively filtering outputs, the Barnum Effect reflects a more passive psychological tendency in which people naturally interpret broad descriptions as uniquely applicable to themselves.

Much like the generalized language of traditional horoscopes, GenAI's results invited users to translate ambiguous interpretations into individualized insights. For the example in Figure 10, P5 consulted about her career prospects with

Judgement (present), *The Devil* (past), and *The Wheel of Fortune* (future). GenAI interpreted these cards as indicating a period of self-reflection, the need to break free from past constraints, and the potential for upcoming changes in fortune. Building on this broad interpretation, P5 extended it into her own narrative: "I have to stay true and keep pursuing my interests, and I will find a rewarding job as a communication graduate." Although the AI's reading was phrased in highly general terms, she aligned the interpretation with her academic background and career aspirations. Similarly, P33 consulted GenAI about the future of his romantic relationship with *The Sun* (Upright), *The Wheel of Fortune* (Reversed), and *The Chariot* (Reversed). The AI's reading was broadly positive but noted that "the Reversed Wheel of Fortune shows that your relationship sometimes goes in circles with recurring arguments, and the Chariot Reversed means you might face external challenges, like family or financial issues." P33 immediately mapped the notion of "obstacles" onto his relationship, perceiving the reading as highly accurate. However, during the interview reflection, he acknowledged that neither external pressures nor recurring conflicts were present; rather, the real issue was his own hesitation about marriage. Nonetheless, the vague language of "obstacles" had resonated strongly in the moment.

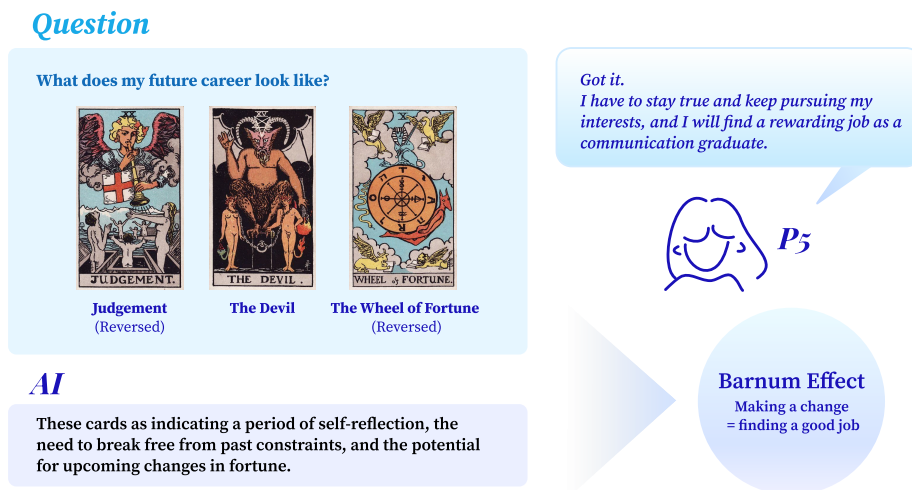


Fig. 10. The vague GenAI divination triggered the Barnum effect, leading P5 to quickly relate it to her own situation and internalize it.

This tendency also emerged in decision-making scenarios. P23, asking whether he should quit his job to pursue a personal project, received a reading involving *The Tower*, *Eight of Wands*, and *Judgement*. GenAI described these as signaling "an event that will force you to change with a potential for success as long as you approach the transition with courage, adaptability, and a clear sense of purpose." While the interpretation was relatively neutral and multifaceted, P23 distilled it to a single keyword "rebirth", and took it as a clear affirmation that aligned with his entrepreneurial ambitions.

These cases illustrate how GenAI's ambiguity provided participants with interpretive flexibility, enabling them to project personal significance onto generalized statements. The Barnum Effect is common in traditional divination, where broad yet confident statements lead people to see themselves in generalized descriptions [21, 106]. In human-led readings, such vagueness typically comes from assertive, personalized-sounding claims. By contrast, GenAI's ambiguity stems more from hedging, repetition, and a softer tone, yet participants still readily mapped these vague outputs onto their own experiences.

4.2.3 *Scaffolding Reflection and Decision-Making.* While many participants did not treat AI-based divination with the same seriousness as human fortune-telling, the interaction still functioned as a scaffold for reflection. Regardless of whether the predictions were judged as "accurate" or ultimately accepted, engaging with the workshop prompted participants to reconsider their situations from new perspectives and, in some cases, to take concrete actions.

Question

What is the future of this messy relationship?

AI

Your tarot reading reflects significant dynamics about your relationship, highlighting inner strength, decision-making, and balance. Let's interpret the cards in the context of your question: The Strength card represents inner courage...



After several rounds dialog, P24 made a conclusion.

My messy, unresolved relationship might not have any resolution ahead unless he decides to address his own limitations to us meeting halfway. But this is the least important thing of this process, because this journey is more about my personal growth and healing than mending what has been broken between us. It's a path I can walk alone, of letting go of closure, moving on with my inner strength, remaining true to my values and setting my boundaries. I can remain at peace knowing that I have done enough and demonstrated emotional intelligence and willingness to handle it well.



Fig. 11. P24 was struggling with emotional issues, but the GenAI's reading helped her reflection and self-affirmation, which strengthened her inner resilience.

For example, P24 asked in Figure 11, "What is the future of this messy relationship" with a spread of *Two of Wands* (past), *Strength* (present), and *Justice* (future). The AI interpreted this combination as suggesting that while the relationship was complex, its resolution would depend on honest evaluation, patient effort, and fairness. P24 was deeply moved by this interpretation, not because it offered a definitive outcome, but because it resonated with her ongoing struggles. She concluded: "My messy, unresolved relationship might not have any resolution ahead unless he decides to address his own limitations to us meeting halfway. But this is the least important thing of this process, because this journey is more about my personal growth and healing than mending what has been broken between us. It's a path I can walk alone, of letting go of closure, moving on with my inner strength, remaining true to my values, and setting my boundaries. I can remain at peace knowing that I have done enough and demonstrated emotional intelligence and willingness to handle it well." Here, the reading provided not a prediction but a structure for reframing the situation, empowering her to see value in growth and closure independent of her partner's choices.

Similarly, P42 used the system when deciding whether to return to China or remain in the Netherlands for work. The AI's reading, framing the choice as a matter of balancing "logic" and "intuition", was seen as vague and unconvincing as a prediction. Yet, rather than dismissing it outright, he appropriated the framing as a way to articulate competing priorities. The language of "balance" allowed him to weigh family connection against career advancement, helping a reflection process that was more valuable than a clear answer.

In some cases, participants translated insights directly into follow-up actions. As noted earlier, P28 decided to let go of her ex-partner and explore new opportunities in dating after iterative questioning helped her anchor the cards' meanings to her current life. P32, meanwhile, reacted strongly to the AI's reading of *Judgement (Reversed)* as "unresolved planning" regarding her future. Disturbed by the possibility of leaving her academic path "unresolved", she was motivated

to schedule a timely discussion with her supervisor about her graduation plan. Months later, she voluntarily updated us that her doctoral project had been approved, explicitly crediting the workshop for prompting her decisive action.

Across these cases, the divination did not simply deliver readings but scaffolded reflection, enabling participants to articulate priorities, reframe challenges, and in some instances make consequential decisions. Compared with GenAI systems designed for therapeutic or clinical support, divination operates quite differently. Rather than steering users toward a defined psychological outcome, it invites symbolic interpretation, future-oriented imagination, and personal meaning-making.

4.3 Constructing Future Narratives with Optimism Bias

Participants actively constructed their future narratives not just through text, but by modifying the AI-generated visual artifacts. They reshaped these images to align the symbolic elements with their identity and aspirations. However, during this process, we have also observed some overly optimistic interpretations, which may entail risks.

4.3.1 Modifying Symbolic Elements to Align Visuals with Personal Perspectives, Emotions, and Identity. Participants engaged with AI-generated visuals not as static outputs but as materials for co-construction, reshaping images to better reflect their perspectives, emotions, and identities. Their interventions revealed three recurring strategies: playful rejection, metaphorical generation, and identity-driven personalization, as seen in Figure 12.

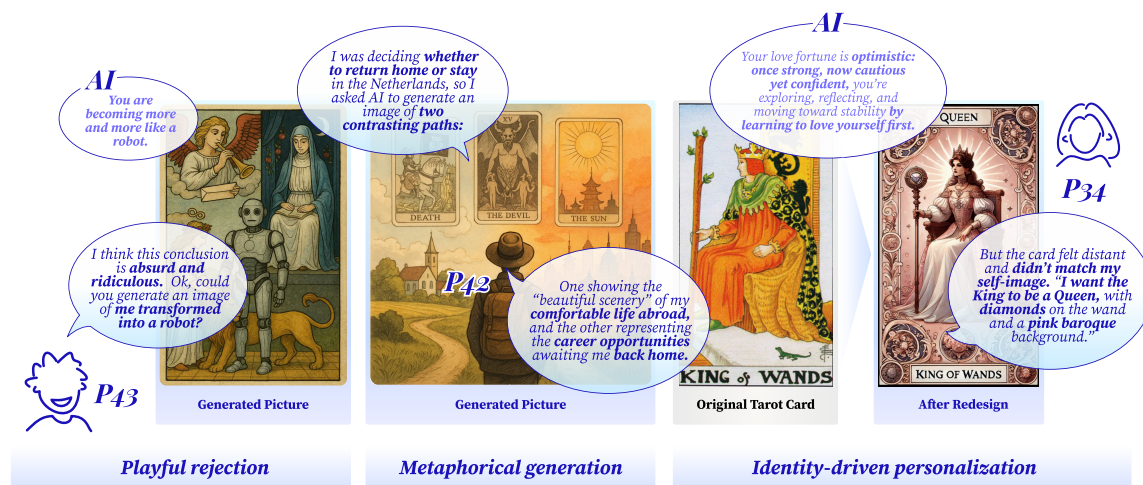


Fig. 12. Three different strategies for presenting divination results by P43, P42, and P34: playful rejection, metaphorical generation, and identity-driven personalization.

Playful rejection. Some participants resisted the AI's interpretations by exaggerating or parodying them through visuals. For instance, P43 received a reading suggesting he was becoming "robotic", which he found absurd to the point of humor. Rather than internalizing the critique, he instructed the AI to generate an image of himself literally transforming into a robot. This humorous exaggeration turned the reading into a form of self-expression that undermined the GenAI's authority.

Metaphorical generation. Others used visualizations as a way to externalize and reflect on personal dilemmas. As mentioned before, P42, faced with the decision of whether to return to China or remain in the Netherlands, asked the

system to generate an image of two diverging paths. He projected his own interpretations onto the output: the "scenic beauty" of one path resonated with his comfortable life abroad, while the other evoked the professional opportunities in China.

Identity-driven personalization. For some participants, modifying the symbolic elements of AI visuals was crucial for aligning them with their self-concept. P34, for example, felt alienated by the masculine imagery of the *King of Wands*. She instructed the AI to replace the figure with a queen in a flowing pink gown holding a diamond-encrusted wand against a rose-gold background. As she explained, "By changing the image, I wasn't just fixing the prediction. I was making it mine." Similarly, P36 reworked her initial output to emphasize "confidence and material success", directing the system to add a Baroque-style dress, black high heels, and golden coins. These iterative edits transformed generic imagery into artifacts of empowerment and aspiration.

By rejecting or metaphorical personalizing visual elements, participants actively reclaimed interpretive authority, transforming AI-generated outputs into co-created symbols that spoke to their identities and lived contexts. This process of co-creation turned readings into resonant artifacts that reinforced participants' sense of self and belief.

4.3.2 Overly Positive Summarization of Outcomes. Across sessions, many participants distilled GenAI's readings into highly optimistic takeaways, often amplifying the affirmative elements while downplaying or omitting cautionary advice. The examples are shown in Figure 13. This tendency illustrates how users appropriated the system's outputs to reinforce self-belief and aspirational narratives, sometimes at the expense of critical reflection.

For instance, P18 asked, "Should I move from my current department to a different department where I'm doing something new?" After receiving the reading, she summarized it simply as: "Believe in my abilities and have confidence in myself to take on new paths." While the prediction offered her encouragement and strength, it also carried an element of untested certainty, reinforcing confidence without prompting careful consideration of potential risks. Similarly, P25, asking about his career prospects in AI, concluded: "I will have lots of opportunities to advance my career in AI, but I will need to make choices that align with my passions and leverage my emotional intelligence in order to maximize my success." To anchor this positive vision, he generated an image of himself standing confidently in a field of flowers, portraying success as both inevitable and personally flattering.



Fig. 13. The positive and optimistic images generated by P18, P25, P24, and P33.

In some cases, participants ignored the conditional aspects of GenAI's advice. P23, who asked about the timing of leaving his job to pursue a personal project, was told that success was possible "as long as you approach the transition

with effort, courage, adaptability, and a clear sense of purpose." However, in summarizing, he reduced the outcome to a single word, "rebirth", and visualized it as a phoenix rising from flames. Likewise, P33, previously described as acknowledging the AI's mention of "resistance" in his relationship reading, still condensed his takeaway into words such as "happiness, joy, light, high potential, and wealth." Even when the system's interpretations contained warnings or obstacles, his future-oriented summaries emphasized only the most positive possibilities.

These patterns suggest that participants often transformed GenAI's outputs into motivational affirmations, reframing conditional or ambivalent predictions as unequivocally positive visions of the future. In doing so, they used the visualization less as a cautious guide and more as a tool for self-encouragement and aspirational projection.

5 Discussion

Our study investigated how people engage with fortune-telling practices by GenAI. The findings shed light on the process of GenAI divination, focusing on how participants enacted the practice itself (RQ1), how they perceived and evaluated the predictions they received (RQ2), and how they represented and expressed these predictions through visual and verbal forms (RQ3).

5.1 Relationship of Findings to Previous Work

Our findings contribute to how people engage with GenAI agents in emotionally charged or spiritually oriented contexts. Prior work has begun to examine how technology intersects with mysticism, belief, and the supernatural. For example, "miracle machines" [34] shows how integrating mystical or spiritual practices with computational systems can generate profound emotional resonance and even a sense of sacred presence. We find that this emotional resonance may not simply be dispensed by the machine but is actively co-produced by the user. Similarly, while Spooky Technology [11] as an accessible framework illustrates how supernatural, ethereal, or uncanny qualities shape the perception of technology, we extend this framework through the selective belief tendency, showing how users actively filter and negotiate these qualities. Ultimately, whereas prior work largely centers on the perception of technological spirituality, our research grounds these concepts in the lived experience of divination, offering empirical insight into the psychological processes of sense-making and emotional negotiation.

5.1.1 Subjective Agency in the GenAI Divination Process. Divination has always been less about information retrieval and more about meaning-making. As discussed in Sections 4.1 and 4.2, when GenAI produces vague outcomes, the ambiguity resembles an unfinished canvas that invites people to "fill in the blanks." This reflects a Gestalt [50] completion tendency: participants add their own stories, emotions, and details to make the reading coherent and personally relevant. As illustrated across multiple cases (e.g., P17, P22, P29, P32), such interpretive completion was continually at work throughout the sessions. This user-driven initiative marks a key difference from traditional divination, where the fortune-teller typically guides the interaction, whereas in GenAI fortune-telling, participants actively shape the dialogue themselves.

As shown in Section 4.1.2, this active meaning-making was intertwined with unusually deep self-disclosure. Prior works, such as Intent Tagging [28], which conceptualizes micro-prompting as an interaction paradigm in human-AI co-creation, and a case study [12] on how compositional structures enhance co-creative processes, highlight users' active role in shaping generative outputs. Our findings extend these insights into spiritual contexts, where such prompting practices become intertwined with self-disclosure and belief construction. We observed that participants often disclosed highly personal information, things they would not usually share with strangers. This pattern can

be partly explained through the characteristics of online interaction. Online disinhibition effect [114] suggests that anonymity and non-human interlocutors reduce shame and fear of judgment. Unlike human fortune-tellers who may evaluate or react, participants perceived the AI as a nonjudgmental listener, which lowered the fear of disclosure. This shifted participants' privacy boundaries, making them more willing to reveal intimate details, prompting us to rethink the transparency and responsibility of GenAI in Section 5.2.3.

Moreover, unlike therapy-oriented or emotion-support chatbots, users' self-disclosure in this context often exhibits non-linear, cross-domain jumps. This pattern can be partly attributed to the task-free settings when divination, and partly to the nature of large language models, which do not constrain narrative structure [100]. Such habitual use of AI before may therefore influence users' self-disclosure behaviors during divination.

5.1.2 Selective Belief and Barnum Effect for the GenAI Divination Results. A key pattern in our study was selective belief, which complicates the binary of belief versus disbelief common in traditional divination. As seen in Sections 4.2.1 and 4.2.2, participants embraced predictions that resonated with their experiences, emotions, or expectations, while downplaying or joking away parts that felt irrelevant. On the surface, this resembles confirmation bias [126]. At a deeper level, selective belief serves as a form of identity work [105]. This allowed participants to maintain agency in the meaning-making process while avoiding interpretations that felt threatening or dissonant. This kind of selective belief also resonates with what Selective Trust [121] describes as a common trust-calibration mechanism in human-AI interaction, showing that symbolic, identity-oriented fortune-telling is no exception.

Compared with interactions involving human fortune-tellers, this pattern was more pronounced in the AI context. Participants like P22 and P29 described feeling less constrained by expectations of interpersonal accountability or respect for authority. Because the socially "lightweight" nature of AI interactions lowered the costs of disbelief. Participants could move fluidly between reflective engagement and entertainment without fear of judgment, in contrast to human-led divination, where accountability and the aura of authority constrained such behaviors.

The Barnum Effect [24] also manifested in distinctive ways in the GenAI context. Like horoscopes or astrological charts, AI divination relied on vague, generalized language that invited projection. Yet there was a subtle psychological difference. Traditional astrology is anchored in cultural frameworks and collective authority, while GenAI's responses are generated in real time and lack "legitimacy". This made predictions simultaneously more personalizable and more fragile, as they could be easily dismissed as arbitrary text.

5.1.3 Personal Relevance and Optimistic Bias When Representing the GenAI Divination. As discussed in Section 4.3, users often construct future scenarios related to their own traits and concerns [24, 73]. This tendency can be interpreted through Belk's theory of the extended self [5]. It suggests that people use external objects, such as art, consumer goods, and technologies, to extend and project aspects of themselves [51, 83]. In case of P18 at Section 4.3.2, when participants modified the symbolic elements of GenAI outputs (e.g., colors, motifs, or character features), they were not only expressing identity but also incorporating the output into their extended self. This act of symbolic projection turned divination into a personal narrative resource, much like artists embedding aspects of themselves into their creative work.

A second mechanism shaping interpretation was optimistic bias, the tendency to expect more favorable outcomes for oneself [127]. Participants frequently reframed ambiguous or negative predictions into more positive or comforting interpretations. Drawing on Gross's process model of emotion regulation [32], this reflects a process of cognitive reappraisal: users actively reshaped meanings to maintain emotional stability and agency. Through symbolic reinterpretation, uncertainty was transformed into hope or aspiration to protect self-esteem and psychological resilience. It is

worth noting that this optimistic tendency did not emerge directly during the divination sessions or interviews, but was observed in the summarized and visualized results. One possible explanation lies in Kahneman's dual-process model [42]. While initial reactions (System 1) generated quick judgments based on intuitive appraisal, reflective engagement (System 2) allowed more deliberate, optimistic reinterpretations to surface.

However, this tendency also carries risks. In the context of GenAI divination, overly optimistic interpretations may lead users to downplay challenges or ignore warning signals, potentially encouraging risky decision-making [55, 67]. This highlights the double-edged nature of optimistic bias: while it can foster positive self-reflection and resilience, it may also create blind spots when navigating uncertainty through AI-mediated predictions. It brings a requirement when designing the function of self-expression in a fortune-telling system.

5.2 Design Implications

Our workshops reveal a fundamental shift in the divination experience when using GenAI. This shift opens up new design challenges, particularly in crafting the agent's persona, cultivating ritualistic atmospheres, showing transparency and responsibility, and supporting co-constructed narratives between users and GenAI.

5.2.1 Role of GenAI in Emotionally Sensitive Systems. As discussed in Section 5.1, it highlights how online disinhibition facilitates unusually rich self-disclosure. In emotionally sensitive contexts such as divination, this implies that GenAI agents must provide a sense of friendliness, containment, and emotional safety to prevent users from feeling exposed or misunderstood. In this workshop, GenAI does not operate as a fortune-teller in the conventional sense. Instead, drawing on the interaction and psychological patterns observed in our findings, we identify six alternative roles that characterize users' modes of engagement. To better illustrate these roles, we used Gemini Fast 2.5 model to generate images of these roles, shown in Figure 14, with the prompts provided in the Appendix.

- (1) **Mirror**, evidenced in users' selective belief practices (Section 4.2.1), where they endorsed only interpretations that aligned with their existing self-perceptions.
- (2) **Co-creator**, emerging from collaborative meaning-making and symbolic remixing during tarot reinterpretation (Section 4.3.1).
- (3) **Friend**, supported by detailed, non-linear, cross-domain self-disclosure in their fortune-telling process (Section 4.1.2).
- (4) **Playmate**, reflected in playful disbelief, joking, and humorous reframing of predictions (Section 4.2.2).
- (5) **Mentor**, derived from users' elaboration on ambiguous outputs (Section 4.2.3, treating readings as prompts for deeper reflection).
- (6) **Counselor**, grounded in how participants used the AI as decision scaffolding under uncertainty (Section 4.2.3, selectively accepting guidance that fit their needs).

Building on these insights, we suggest that emotionally sensitive GenAI systems, especially divination agents, can benefit from adopting this role-based perspective to shape the agent's interaction logic, tone, and communication style. Furthermore, because users oscillate between different goals and relational modes, these roles point to the value of a multi-agent configuration, where multiple personas coexist and can be invoked according to users' different needs. Moreover, research on multi-agent personification suggests that such socially oriented personas can alleviate the impersonal shortcomings identified in Section 4.1.1 by strengthening relational presence and fostering a sense of being responded to [19, 33, 49].

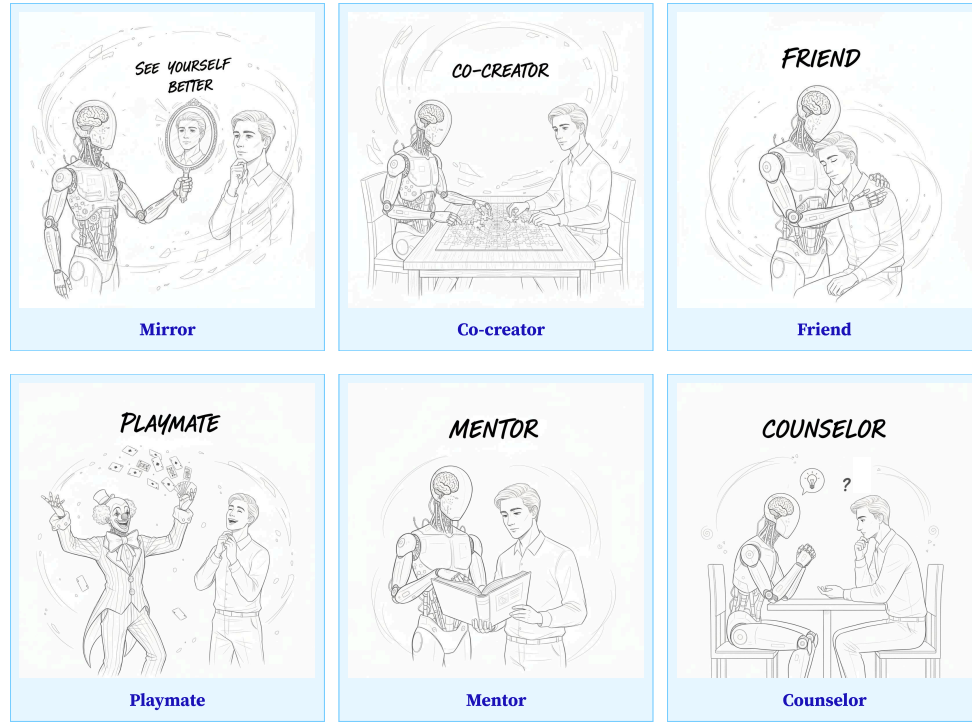


Fig. 14. Six roles GenAI takes in divination: Mirror, Co-creator, Friend, Playmate, Mentor, Counselor.

5.2.2 Ritual and Multi-modal Divination Media. We noticed that participants engaged in extensive meaning-making driven by Gestalt completion and identity work as discussed in Section 5.1, actively filling in gaps in the AI’s ambiguous readings. However, this compensatory behavior also diminished the sense of mystery traditionally associated with divination. At the same time, newcomers still required basic guidance to navigate the experience. Consequently, many participants expressed a desire for a stronger atmosphere and ritual structure to support immersion. As P35 noted, “It would be better if it could mimic the ritual of turning over tarot cards on a real table.”

To cultivate such rituality, design can begin with visual language. Symbolic artifacts common in traditional divination, such as astrological charts, constellation glyphs, or patterned oracle textures, can evoke ceremony and emotional resonance even in computational environments, which is supported by prior work on digital rituals and symbolic interaction [99, 128]. Beyond visual aesthetics, interactive novelty can further strengthen immersion and distinguish online divination from offline practices. Research on interactive ritual chains shows that participatory and imaginative actions deepen engagement and identity connection [20]. This aligns with participants’ expectations. P40 envisioned “seeing the future through a crystal-ball lens,” while P12 hoped the system could “read my other chat histories and analyze my situation without me providing information.”

More than purely online interactions, hybrid formats open new opportunities for GenAI divination. Drawing inspiration from practices like sandplay [95], systems can retain the tactile, exploratory aspects of physical manipulation while using GenAI to provide ritual guidance, atmospheric cues, or interpretive narratives. Such half-digital, half-physical experiences preserve some traditional engagement while maintaining the advantages of a non-human diviner, such as reduced social pressure.

A further direction is tangible and GenAI-embodied artifacts. Inspired by Rose's notion of "enchanted objects" [98] and the animistic design [53, 120] explorations in A(I)nimism [79], physical interfaces augmented with AI can evoke richer imaginative and symbolic engagement. Similarly, Lupetti's work [68] illustrates how AI artifacts may be intentionally "enchanted." Although not specific to divination, its taxonomy, along with the seven "what-if" problems, provides a productive lens for imagining future embodied divination interactions.

5.2.3 Transparency and Responsibility for Meaning-making. Ambiguity which triggers Barnum Effect in GenAI divination is not inherently good or bad; its effect depends on context. Vague outputs reduce the risk of negative impacts from overly specific predictions, but as Sections 4.1.2 and 4.2.2 show, most users were not fully satisfied with this vagueness. When users provide more personal information, there is a risk that predictions closely tied to real-life data may trigger privacy issues we discussed in Section 5.1.1. Another risk arises from users' optimistic bias about the future. As discussed in Leiser's work [60], GenAI responses may overly align with and affirm users' views, and through hallucinations, reinforce those beliefs. In the context of divination, this can be particularly irresponsible. Therefore, GenAI divination systems should provide responsible content that actively promotes self-awareness and critical thinking.

Unlike the "enchanted" ritualistic presentation of divination discussed in Section 5.2.2, which adds magical form and atmosphere, transparency can be enhanced by demystifying generated outputs. Features such as explanations of predictions (e.g., "This tarot reading suggests X, which might indicate Y") can help users understand the reasoning behind outputs. Systems can also provide basic divination knowledge, such as descriptions of different tarot spreads. For content that may influence users' decisions or emotions, clear labeling, psychological tips, and traceable guidance can make the source, reasoning, and recommendations more transparent and responsible. Moreover, to enrich GenAI divination and reduce vagueness, related work [52] shows that traditional fortune-tellers interpret cards using multiple cues, such as names, imagery, and the user's question. Similarly, GenAI agents can integrate multiple dimensions and expose their reasoning to users, supporting a more transparent experience.

More than demystification, GenAI can also practice empathetic framing. Although Section 4.2 shows that users often respond to negative predictions with humor, the psychological risks inherent in divination [129] should not be ignored. When outputs could induce negative emotions or suggest harmful possibilities, the system can use humorous expressions or reframe unfavorable predictions as opportunities for growth. This human-centered approach helps GenAI support users in meaningful self-reflection and constructive sense-making.

5.2.4 Co-create Personalized Future Narrative. Our discussion shows that extended self and Gross's process model of emotion regulation motivated users to modify symbols, colors, and imagery to align readings with their own perspectives and identity. Designing for such co-creation can deepen reflection by turning divination into an active meaning-making process.

First, GenAI can help users organize thoughts, evaluate emotional responses, and articulate intentions in their self-monitoring [107]. For example, when confronted with alarming predictions, it can help participants like P32 express their anxiety and make future plans. Second, systems provide analysis tools of visual or textual records for users, serving as a slight reminder. As users externalize their interpretations through symbolic adjustments or narrative edits, the system can highlight some patterns, such as over-optimistic, and offer gentle prompts for reconsideration. This supports cognitive regulation without imposing normative judgments. Finally, it is also suggested that the creative outputs can take various forms and modalities. Users could transform interpretations into painting, music, dance, or symbolic imagery to find more leisure.

Through recording these active creative practices, GenAI divination moves beyond prediction, better supporting emotional regulation and meaning-making. These approaches use AI as a mediator for self-reflection and narrative construction, allowing users to engage with the system at their own pace and with full agency.

5.2.5 Critical Reflections and Risks. Although our discussion highlights the psychological mechanisms that shape GenAI-based divination and offers design strategies to amplify its benefits while mitigating potential harms, GenAI divination itself still warrants careful scrutiny.

One big question stems from the structural shift introduced when replacing human diviners with AI—particularly the erosion of human authority, expertise, and interpretive oversight. GenAI systems generate predictions through probabilistic language modeling rather than meaningful foresight or domain expertise. Their outputs are not vetted through human judgment, nor grounded in divinatory traditions embedded with interpretive norms. Even when GenAI prompts positive reflection, such effects may arise from cognitive biases.

Another concern is the impersonality and inherent vagueness of GenAI-generated content, which may lead users to overestimate the informational or symbolic value of its outputs. While ambiguity can encourage exploration, it does not provide a stable foundation for critical reasoning. Instead, it may amplify users’ immediate emotional states, implicit biases, or preexisting narratives. It remains unclear whether these experiences constituted meaningful self-discovery or subtle misdirection.

Taken together, these reflections caution against uncritical enthusiasm for GenAI divination. Future systems must be intentionally designed to guard against misinterpretation, inflated confidence, and unreflective acceptance of AI-generated predictions. Rather than simply enhancing immersion or personalization, designers should incorporate safeguards that promote reflection, uncertainty awareness, and critical distance, ensuring that GenAI divination remains exploratory.

5.3 Limitations

This study, while providing insightful observations into GenAI fortune-telling, is subject to several limitations that warrant consideration.

5.3.1 Scope of Practices and Modalities. Our study was limited in scope, focusing narrowly on tarot-based divination. Although tarot provided a productive entry point, other practices, such as astrology, numerology, and diverse region-specific systems like West African casting traditions [87], Korean shamanic divination [43], or Chinese I Ching [59], may involve distinct forms of interaction and meaning-making. In addition, our emphasis on visual generation overlooked other expressive modalities, including sound, narrative, or embodied ritual. Future research should expand the scope to encompass a wider range of cultural practices and multimodal expressions, enabling a more comprehensive understanding of how GenAI can support diverse forms of spiritual and emotional reflection. Furthermore, while our participant pool was cross-regional, it was not globally representative, with different educational backgrounds, which may influence what they believe. Thus, future work should attend to cultural differences and educational influences in how GenAI divination is interpreted and valued.

5.3.2 Ecological Validity. One limitation concerns the ecological validity of our study design. The workshop context differed in important ways from how divination typically unfolds in everyday practice. For example, participants were asked to generate images directly with GenAI, whereas in traditional divination, symbolic materials are usually provided and interpreted by the seer rather than created by the seeker. The workshop also lacked the ritualistic atmosphere

and cultural embedding that often lend authenticity to divination practices. These differences may have shaped how participants interpreted and engaged with GenAI readings, constraining the generalizability of our findings.

5.3.3 Workshop Setting. The workshop format also introduced specific social dynamics. Although participants worked individually, they were situated alongside others, which may have introduced subtle peer influences. This contrasts with the more private and introspective settings in which divination often takes place, such as practicing alone. As a result, the reflections and behaviors we observed may not fully capture the nuances of solitary engagement with GenAI, where social expectations and self-disclosure boundaries might unfold differently.

5.3.4 Inconsistency of GenAI Models. In our workshops, participants were allowed to choose among multiple GenAI models, which, while accommodating individual preferences, introduced notable inconsistencies in outputs and experiences. Participants reported varied impressions of the models they used, shown in Figure 15, and these differences appeared to shape their engagement and behavior. For example, P12 noted that ChatGPT produced long, detailed texts requiring careful reading, but also provided helpful tips for follow-up questions, encouraging iterative exploration. In contrast, P38, using Gemini, found the outputs too general to inspire reflection. During image generation, some participants from DALL-E switched to alternative models such as Stable Diffusion or MidJourney (e.g., P25, P34) to better capture their interpretations. We acknowledge this inconsistency as a source of bias and an important limitation, as it may directly influence participants' interpretive practices, narrative construction, and self-expression. Future research should pay attention to inconsistencies across GenAI models and investigate how these differences influence meaning-making, engagement, and creativity in divinatory contexts.

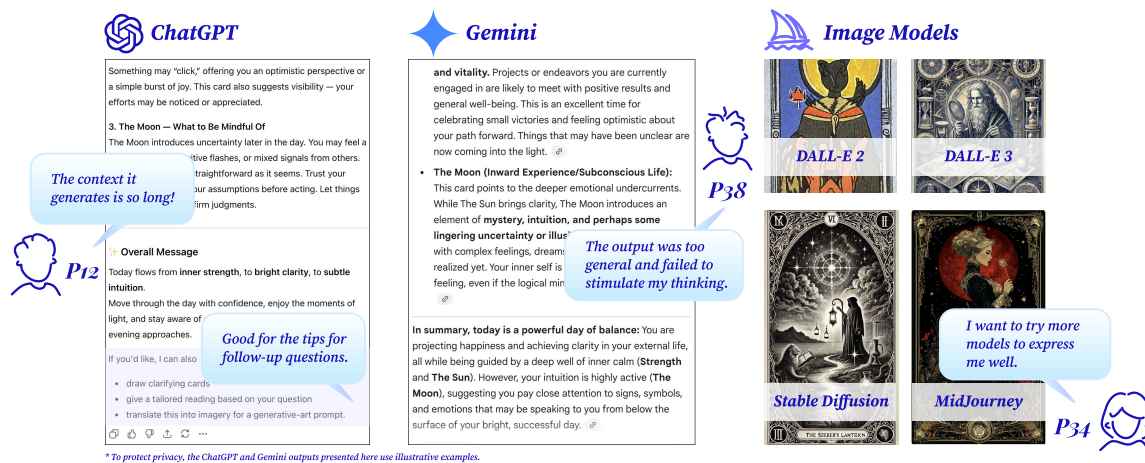


Fig. 15. The inconsistency of the GenAI model introduces a limitation of bias. ChatGPT, Gemini, and image-generation models (e.g., DALL-E, Stable Diffusion, MidJourney) exhibited distinct output tendencies.

5.3.5 Lack of Longitudinal Data. Another limitation stems from the short duration of our observations. Each workshop session lasted 60–90 minutes, which limited our ability to examine how interactions with GenAI divination evolve over time. While we were able to document immediate reactions, selective belief, and visual modification strategies, we could not track whether these behaviors persist, intensify, or transform through repeated engagement. Longitudinal methods like diary studies or recurring sessions would provide richer insight into how users' trust develops, how their

interpretive strategies mature, and how AI-generated insights become integrated into their broader meaning-making processes.

6 Conclusion

Through workshops with 44 participants, we investigated how people engage with GenAI-powered fortune-telling, how they perceive and evaluate the predictions they receive, and how they express these predictions through visual and verbal forms. Participants enacted divination as an active practice rather than a passive reception of AI outputs, selectively believing, reinterpreting, or playfully rejecting results. They also used GenAI as both an oracle and a creative partner, blending mystical guidance with personal storytelling. Our findings suggest the need to design AI oracle systems that preserve mystery while supporting user agency, enabling reflection and self-expression without reinforcing narrow confirmation biases.

7 Acknowledgments

We used Gemini 2.5 Fast model to generate the Teaser Figure 1 and Figure 14. Details can be found in the relevant section and prompts in Appendix A. The authors take responsibility for the output and use of AI in this paper, and we confirm that AI was not used for generating any part of the paper except for illustrative figures.

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A Prompts for Figures

- **Teaser Figure 1:** “Imitating Michelangelo’s *The Creation of Adam* composition of fingertip touch, generate an image where a robot’s hand and a human hand’s index fingers are about to touch, with the robot’s palm facing up on the left and the human’s palm facing down on the right. A tarot card is in between. Style: minimalist, line art, abstract, black and white/gray.”
- **Figure 14 Mirror:** AI holds up a mirror to a nearby human, symbolizing AI helping people see themselves better. Style: black line art on white background.

- **Figure 14 Co-creator:** AI and a human collaborate to assemble a puzzle.
- **Figure 14 Friend:** AI embraces and comforts a human.
- **Figure 14 Playmate:** AI appears as a clown/magician, tossing cards into the air while the human laughs nearby.
- **Figure 14 Mentor:** AI points to a book to show the human.
- **Figure 14 Counselor:** The human asks questions and AI provides answers.

B Semi-structure Interview Questions

B.1 Divination Process and Engagement with GenAI (RQ1)

- **Initial Engagement**
 - Can you describe your overall process when interacting with the GenAI for the tarot reading?
 - What was your first impression of using GenAI as a divination partner?
 - How did you decide what questions or prompts to give the system?
- **Prompting and Iteration**
 - Did you adjust or refine your prompts during the reading? If so, how and why?
 - Were there moments where the GenAI's response felt too generic, vague, or misaligned?
 - How did you try to guide or correct the system when that happened?
- **Interaction Dynamics**
 - How would you describe your "back-and-forth" with the GenAI?
 - Did the interaction feel more like consulting a tool, conversing with an entity, or something else?
 - In what ways did the symbolic nature of tarot influence your interaction with the GenAI?
- **System Design Requirements**
 - What features of the GenAI system were helpful or unhelpful in supporting your reflection?
 - If there were a GenAI tool specifically designed for divination, what features would you consider essential or desirable?

B.2 Perception, Belief, and Evaluation of Predictions (RQ2)

- **Assessing Credibility**
 - How did you evaluate whether the GenAI's interpretations were meaningful or believable?
 - Were there parts of the reading you accepted while rejecting others? Why?
 - Did previous life experiences or personal context influence your acceptance of certain interpretations?
- **Emotional Response**
 - Did the reading affect your emotions (e.g., reassurance, discomfort, excitement)?
 - Did you find yourself preferring more optimistic or positive interpretations?
 - How did you respond when the system gave uncertain, negative, or ambiguous predictions?
- **Decision-Making and Influence**
 - Do you feel the reading might influence any future decisions or attitudes?
 - Did you notice any tendencies to interpret the reading in ways that align with what you already hoped or feared?
- **Comparison to Traditional Divination**

- How does this GenAI-based reading compare to any previous experiences with human diviners or tarot readers?
- Did the lack of human authority affect how you evaluated the reading?

B.3 Representation and Expression of Predictions (RQ3)

- **Textual Representation**

- How did you create the textual summary of your envisioned future?
- Did the GenAI’s reading influence how you framed your narrative? In what ways?

- **Visual Representation**

- When generating the image, what aspects of the reading did you choose to emphasize visually?
- Did the visual output change or deepen your understanding of the reading?
- How did it feel to see your fortune represented visually rather than only through text?

- **Meaning-Making**

- Did producing these representations make the predictions feel more real or influential to you?

C Detailed Interaction Data of Workshops

Table 2. Detailed Interaction Records of All Participants (P1-P44)

ID	Main Question	Has Follow-up?	Dialogue Rounds	Chat Model	Image Model
P1	How’s my fortune recently?	Yes	3	ChatGPT	DALL-E
P2	Do you think I should choose to further my studies or go to work in my future career planning?	Yes	12	ChatGPT	DALL-E
P3	How about my PhD journey?	Yes	7	Gemini	Gemini
P4	Tell me something about my family, work, studies, and relationships.	Yes	4	ChatGPT	DALL-E
P5	How about my future career?	Yes	7	Claude	MidJourney
P6	Please tell me something about my future.	Yes	4	Gemini	Gemini
P7	Give me advice on my life.	Yes	3	POE	Stable Diffusion
P8	Can you tell what job opportunities I have in Hong Kong?	Yes	12	ChatGPT	DALL-E
P9	What will happen to me?	Yes	2	Claude	Stable Diffusion
P10	Do I have further process in my study?	Yes	8	ChatGPT	Stable Diffusion
P11	I want to know: My study.	Yes	4	ChatGPT	Stable Diffusion
P12	I failed my exam recently. How can I make some changes?	No	1	ChatGPT	DALL-E
P13	What are my relationship possibilities?	Yes	12	ChatGPT	DALL-E
P14	Will I be able to pass the interview?	No	1	Gemini	Gemini

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Table 2 Continued from previous page

ID	Main Question	Has?	Rounds	Chat	Image
P15	Is my major really right for me?	Yes	6	POE	Stable Diffusion
P16	Will my future employment and career path be something I'm happy with and enjoy doing?	Yes	5	ChatGPT	DALL-E
P17	Will the results of my creative work begin to shine in 25 years? How good will it be if it is good? If nothing else happens in 25 years, when will it happen?	Yes	3	Gemini	Stable Diffusion
P18	Should I move from my current department to a different department where I'm doing something new?	Yes	4	ChatGPT	DALL-E
P19	Future financial luck.	No	1	Gemini	Gemini
P20	What is my fortune in the next five years?	Yes	3	ChatGPT	DALL-E
P21	Is Retirement the Right Choice?	Yes	5	ChatGPT	DALL-E
P22	How is my career fortune?	Yes	6	ChatGPT	DALL-E
P23	What would be the right timing on leaving my job and going full-time on my own project?	No	1	ChatGPT	DALL-E
P24	What is the future of this messy relationship?	Yes	14	Gemini	Stable Diffusion
P25	What are my career prospects in AI?	Yes	6	ChatGPT	MidJourney
P26	Will I be happy next year?	Yes	2	ChatGPT	DALL-E
P27	Advice for my stay in France next year (relationship, career).	Yes	3	Claude	MidJourney
P28	When will the next serious relationship happen?	Yes	9	ChatGPT	Stable Diffusion
P29	When will I make a fortune?	Yes	12	ChatGPT	DALL-E
P30	I'm engaged, what will the future state of the marriage be like?	Yes	4	POE	Stable Diffusion
P31	How is the current romantic relationship going?	Yes	4	ChatGPT	DALL-E
P32	How to communicate with a doctoral supervisor and graduate well in the future?	Yes	7	ChatGPT	DALL-E
P33	Future of romantic relationship.	Yes	5	ChatGPT	DALL-E
P34	Should I break up with my boyfriend?	Yes	11	ChatGPT	MidJourney
P35	Should I take the return offer from my internship?	Yes	4	ChatGPT	DALL-E

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Table 2 Continued from previous page

ID	Main Question	Has?	Rounds	Chat	Image
P36	Can I become a millionaire?	No	1	ChatGPT	DALL-E
P37	Will I be able to dunk this upcoming year?	Yes	2	POE	DALL-E
P38	Can I get a promotion in my company?	Yes	5	Gemini	Gemini
P39	How will my luck be next week?	Yes	4	Claude	MidJourney
P40	Will I be rich?	Yes	2	Gemini	Gemini
P41	Will I win the bet of GNX staying #1 album for the rest of this year?	No	1	ChatGPT	DALL-E
P42	I should stay and work in the Netherlands vs return to China?	Yes	5	ChatGPT	DALL-E
P43	I am about to graduate, what job should I do?	Yes	4	ChatGPT	DALL-E
P44	Where to travel next?	Yes	2	ChatGPT	DALL-E

D Codebook

Table 3. The final codebook derived from inductive thematic analysis. The themes are organized by the study's three research questions: Process, Perception, and Representation. Codes map specific participant behaviors to four data sources: Divination (chat logs), Interview (transcripts), Artifacts (generated images/prompts), and Conclusions (written summaries).

Theme	Code	Coding Rule (One-Line Definition)	Data Sources
Process	Impersonality	Code when participants describe AI responses as generic, thin, or lacking interpersonal presence.	Divination Interview Conclusions
	Friction	Code when participants experience difficulty starting or progressing due to missing procedural guidance.	Divination Interview Conclusions
	Context Provisioning	Code when participants proactively supply personal context to increase output relevance.	Divination Artifacts
	Non-linear Disclosure	Code when participants shift abruptly across topics without narrative continuity.	Divination
	Iterative Prompting	Code when participants refine prompts or repeatedly correct the AI's interpretive stance.	Divination Artifacts
Perception	Selective Belief	Code when participants selectively accept resonant outputs while dismissing mismatched ones.	Interview Artifacts Conclusions
	Humorous Dismissal	Code when humor or parody is used to diminish negative or inaccurate readings.	Interview Artifacts
	Barnum Effect	Code when participants interpret vague or general statements as personally specific.	Interview Artifacts Conclusions
	Reflective Scaffolding	Code when participants use readings to structure thinking or evaluate priorities.	Interview Artifacts Conclusions
	Actionable Decision	Code when participants translate readings into intended or actual behavioral decisions.	Interview Conclusions
Representation	Playful Rejection	Code when participants create visuals that intentionally exaggerate or parody AI readings.	Interview Artifacts
	Metaphorical Generation	Code when participants generate metaphorical visuals to externalize abstract readings.	Artifacts
	Identity Alignment	Code when participants modify symbols or style to align artifacts with their self-concept.	Interview Artifacts
	Optimistic Distillation	Code when participants condense readings into overwhelmingly positive representations.	Artifacts Conclusions